

FAR HORIZONS
Former CM Amarinder Singh at his farmhouse in Siswan, near Chandigarh

CM candidate
AMARINDER SINGH, 79

Alliance partners
BJP, SAD (Sanyukt)

CHALLENGES

- Residual anger over the BJP's attempt to ram through farm reforms
- Amarinder Singh's anti-incumbency baggage
- Alliance partner BJP's lack of pan-Punjab presence
- Delays in kicking off campaign and ticket distribution

that I want to join your fight but I am not going to join your party. He accepted it and asked me to call and speak to the prime minister the next day." Amarinder soon got a taste of just how early Narendra Modi works, when at 6.30 am he was woken up by a call from Shah who said the PM was on the line and wanted to speak to him. The PM expressed his happiness at the development and thus began the alliance between the PLC and the BJP. The BJP offered 37 seats and Amarinder agreed because, as he put it, "It was based on the availability of candidates. I could probably have asked for 10 more seats, but we are a new party and we didn't want to take on more than we could chew."

The BJP soon realised how difficult it would be for the PLC to get its act together. A BJP office-bearer remarks, "We had to do most of the organising for them and getting money for their candidates to fight. It was like running two parties." Five of Amarinder's candidates have, in fact, opted to fight on the BJP symbol. With that, the party is contesting 73 seats—the largest number they have ever contested in Punjab. The party also tied up with Sukhdev Singh Dhindsa's SAD (Sanyukt), giving it 16 seats. The BJP's game plan is that, with Amarinder and Dhindsa on their side, they have two credible Jat Sikhs who could help them gain access to that side of the landscape while the party consoli-